The Chattanooga Guides Series

Weekend in Chattanooga: Choo Choo District Guide

Original Author: Jack Byram

Read time: 8 minutes

Last updated: 11/03/2026

Published on: 02/22/2026

Neighborhoods: Southside, Downtown

Seasonality: Year-round

Best for: Weekend visitors, First-time Chattanooga guests, Staycation

#around-the-city

Get our local guides and events updates.

First name | Email | Get Our Updates

This guide covers one day in the Choo Choo District, from morning coffee to nightlife. It is built for locals hosting out of town guests, not for visitors arriving cold.

The Choo Choo terminal anchors the south end of downtown Chattanooga, near Market Street and Station Street. Most places listed here are within a ten minute walk of each other. That density makes it easier to keep a group moving without planning logistics in advance.

The district leans toward visitors. That is the honest read. But many of the restaurants and bars here have a regular local crowd. You are not choosing convenience over quality.

The guide is organized by time of day: morning, afternoon, dinner, and nightlife. Use the table of contents above to jump to the section you need. A few places appear in more than one section because they work at different points of the day.

This post focuses on food and drink. For daytime activity ideas near the Choo Choo, see the outdoors guide or the exhibits guide.

Missing a spot? Send an email and it will be considered for the next update.

By Topic.

Where to Stay
Beginning Your Day
Middle of the Day
Evening
Bonus

Where to Stay.

Your guests have the unique option of staying in a room at the Choo Choo itself, inside one of the train cars. Availability can be limited, so other strong options nearby include the Moxy Hotel, Kinley Hotel, and The Hotel Chalet.

My guests chose to stay at the Moxy, which is about a three minute walk to the Choo Choo. On the first floor, the Moxy also has a large bar and gathering area for guests to enjoy while making plans for the day or evening. It can also serve as your first stop if your plans are already set.

Now that you have chosen a place to stay, let's walk through options for beginning your day, filling the afternoon, and wrapping up the evening.

Beginning Your Day.

For the Up Before Breakfast Crowd.

Start your day with a caffeine fix from either The Hot Chocolatier or Mean Mug. Both offer a range of hot drinks and sweet treats to get things going. For a wider map of roasters, brunch cafes, and neighborhood shops across the metro, see the Chattanooga coffee shops guide. If you are looking specifically for desserts around Chattanooga, check out our dedicated guide.

Breakfast.

Once the rest of your group is awake and ready to break the fast, here are some walkable options:

Frothy Monkey, located inside the Choo Choo Plaza.

The Exchange, across the street at the Kinley Hotel, open seven days a week from 7am with coffee and baked goods in the morning that give way to cocktails and small plates by night.

Neidlov's Cafe and Bakery, for a less formal cafe experience with baked goods, sandwiches, and coffee.

Middle of the Day.

You likely already have daytime plans, but if you need to fill some extra time, here are a few options in the Choo Choo area.

This is one of the more popular photo areas in Chattanooga. You can take photos at the Chattanooga sign, around the train cars, and inside the main hall, which sometimes features seasonal centerpieces such as a Christmas tree or even a pop up roller skating rink.

For those interested in art, there are two nearby galleries:

Hart Gallery Tennessee, which sells art and crafts made by local homeless and other nontraditional artists.

Gallery 1401, a nearby modern art gallery.

You can also take a whiskey tour at Chattanooga Whiskey. Tours last about an hour and walk you through their distilling and bottling process while explaining differences between batches. A flight of whiskey is included with your ticket.

For something lighthearted, get your caricature drawn at HartsFartsy Caricature Couch. Past visitors describe the artist as engaging and entertaining, and you leave with one of a kind art.

If your visit lands during baseball season, the Chattanooga Lookouts now play at Erlanger Park, their new ballpark in the South Broad District that opened in April 2026. It is a short drive south of the Choo Choo, or a longer walk down the Tennessee Riverwalk, which runs right through the stadium grounds. Even without a game on the schedule, the walk down and back is an easy way to fill an afternoon. See the live sports guide for the Lookouts schedule and other local sports options.

Evening.

Dinner.

Here are three recommended dinner spots within walking distance, followed by a bonus option I have not personally tried but may be worth checking out.

Nic and Norman's is a burger and Southern comfort food restaurant with a full bar, run by filmmaker Greg Nicotero and actor Norman Reedus. It is located inside the Choo Choo.

Feed Table and Tavern is a local favorite known for interesting menu options like chili pot roast or grass fed sloppy joes. It has a lively atmosphere and a full bar.

Elsie's Daughter is a French-Appalachian bistro inside The Hotel Chalet at the Choo Choo. Main courses rotate but may include a roasted half chicken or short rib ragu.

Bonus pick: **Bluegrass Grill**, a highly rated Southern style restaurant serving both breakfast and dinner, though I have not personally been.

A few newer spots have opened within a short walk on the Southside. I have not worked them into a full visit yet, but they are worth a look.

The Trinity serves New Orleans food and drinks at 1278 Market Street. It opened in August 2026 in the old St. John's building. It runs dinner every night and brunch on weekends.

Bona Fide is a small restaurant and bar at 55 Johnson Street. The menu changes with the season and leans on housemade pasta and small plates. It opened in July 2026.

Alleia is a long-running local favorite for rustic Italian at 25 East Main Street. Expect housemade pasta, wood-fired dishes, and a deep wine list. Book ahead on weekends.

Dessert.

If you have left room after dinner, there is Clumpies, a homegrown ice cream shop just across the street from the Choo Choo that is known for its process and rotating flavors.

Around the corner from Clumpies is Insomnia Cookies, where you can sample warm cookies from the day's menu.

After Dinner Non Alcohol Options.

The Comedy Catch, located at the Choo Choo, may have a show running. Check their calendar for tickets. We also have guides to live music and performing arts for more options.

The Signal and Barrelhouse Ballroom are nearby music venues that feature both regional and national acts. Check their calendars for live performances.

Cocktail and Happy Hour.

For an evening cocktail, you have several choices. I recommend the back outdoor bar at Gate 11 Distillery when the weather cooperates. They distill their own spirits on site, including a gin that has won awards worldwide, and make excellent handcrafted cocktails. The Gimlet or Mule are both strong choices.

Elsie's Daughter is also known for its cocktails, and Stir offers a lively atmosphere.

If you are up for a short trip into downtown, Iris opened in early 2026 on the 11th floor of the Waymark Hotel, inside a restored 1927 bank building. You get signature cocktails and one of the

higher skyline views in the city. Downstairs, the building's old bank vault is now a hidden speakeasy called The Vault.

If you prefer beer, there are three breweries in or near the Choo Choo. See the **breweries and wineries guide** for the full regional picture.

TailGate Brewery next door.

Five Wits across the street.

Wanderlinger Brewing on Station Street.

It is good to have options.

Nightlife.

Many of the places mentioned above become lively as the evening progresses, so do not feel pressured to keep moving if you have found your spot. However, if you are looking for additional nightlife options, Station Street next to the Choo Choo offers the following.

Backstage Bar has a wide whiskey menu, rotating draft beers, live music, and a strong patio scene. It is open until 2am on Fridays and Saturdays.

The Boneyard hosts nontraditional events such as Drag Night and Goth Night in addition to regular music events.

Reagan's Retro Bar has more of a club atmosphere. If you are looking for dancing and DJs, this is your spot.

Bonus.

You have two gaming options. The Classic Arcade Pinball Museum downtown charges one flat price for unlimited play on over 40 machines. At The Boneyard on Station Street, pinball sits alongside the bar and no extra ticket is required.

The Choo Choo District works because of the density. Most places in this guide sit within two blocks of the main plaza. You can cover a full day without moving a car once.

This guide gets updated as new places open and others close. If a spot on this list has changed, or you think something belongs here, send an email. For scenic dining a short drive from the Choo Choo, see the restaurants with a view guide.

FAQ.

Where should my guests stay near the Chattanooga Choo Choo?

Three hotels are within a few minutes' walk: the Choo Choo hotel itself, the Moxy Hotel about three minutes away, and the Kinley Hotel across Market Street. Hotel Chalet is also nearby. The Choo Choo has rooms inside restored train cars, but availability is limited. Book those early.

What restaurants are closest to the Choo Choo?

Frothy Monkey is inside the Choo Choo complex and runs all day for coffee and food. Nic and Norman's serves burgers and Southern comfort food inside the terminal. Feed Table and Tavern and Elsie's Daughter are both a short walk away on the Southside strip.

Is there live music near the Choo Choo?

Yes. The Signal and Barrelhouse Ballroom are both nearby and book regional and national touring acts. Comedy Catch runs shows at the Choo Choo complex. Gate 11 Distillery hosts a free weekly Blues Jam on Monday nights at 7:30pm.

What are the best photo spots at the Choo Choo?

The Chattanooga sign in the main hall is the most photographed spot. The restored train cars photograph well in good light. The main hall sometimes has a seasonal centerpiece, like a Christmas tree or a pop-up skating rink, that adds to the backdrop.

What is on Station Street next to the Choo Choo?

Station Street runs along the Choo Choo complex. Backstage Bar has a patio, live music, and stays open until 2am on weekends. The Boneyard hosts events like Drag Night and Goth Night. Reagan's Retro Bar focuses on dancing and DJs. Wanderlinger Brewing is also on the street.

Other Guides.

Guided Tours

City history, ghost, kayak, cave

Live Music

Venues, festivals, local artists

Outdoor Adventures

Hiking, kayaking, climbing

Sweet Treats

Chocolate, ice cream, candy shops

← All things to do in Chattanooga

©2026 thingshappening